

Gandhi's views on the railways had softened considerably by the 1920s. The means of building and expansion of the railways may have been exploitative, but the character of the enterprise itself underwent a dramatic change as the Indian freedom movement increased in scale. The railways were now the means to quickly connect with like-minded compatriots and to spread the word of self-rule among all. His incessant political activity, necessitated the use of the railways. During the Non-cooperation movement (1920–22), when Gandhi was on a nationwide tour, he would persuade the mobs that thronged the station for a *darshan* (glimpse), to discard their headgear and *dupattas* (scarf-like garment) on the spot and light a bonfire to boycott foreign cloth.

Gandhi's relationship with the railways would follow him beyond his temporal body. Upon his death in 1948, when the man and the myth of the Mahatma had become inseparable, an urn filled with his ashes was placed in a train made up of five third-class carriages. The Asthi Special wove its way from city to city in north India, till it reached Allahabad, where the Mahatma's mortal remains were immersed into the River Ganges.

“It must be *manifest* to you that, but for *the railways*, the *English* could not have such a *hold on India* as they have.”

MK GANDHI, *HIND SWARAJ* (1909)